The Fourteen Points

President Woodrow Wilson · Address to Joint Session of Congress · January 8, 1918

Source: Woodrow Wilson, Address to Congress ('Fourteen Points,' Jan. 8, 1918), text via the Avalon Project, Yale Law School. Public domain.

Wilson laid out his vision for a post-war peace nine months before the Armistice. The plan called for open diplomacy, freedom of the seas, free trade, disarmament, self-determination for European nationalities, and — point fourteen — a 'general association of nations' that became the League of Nations. The U.S. Senate rejected the Treaty of Versailles in 1919–20 and the U.S. never joined the League.

Connect: Wilson pushed the League of Nations while the Senate refused. This isn't the first time Congress checked a president's foreign policy. Compare with Washington's Farewell warnings (Class 7).

Key Passages

Wilson's framing

> What we demand in this war, therefore, is nothing peculiar to ourselves. It is that the world be made fit and safe to live in; and particularly that it be made safe for every peace-loving nation which, like our own, wishes to live its own life, determine its own institutions, be assured of justice and fair dealing by the other peoples of the world as against force and selfish aggression.

Selected points

> I. Open covenants of peace, openly arrived at, after which there shall be no private international understandings of any kind but diplomacy shall proceed always frankly and in the public view. II. Absolute freedom of navigation upon the seas, outside territorial waters, alike in peace and in war … III. The removal, so far as possible, of all economic barriers and the establishment of an equality of trade conditions among all the nations consenting to the peace … IV. Adequate guarantees given and taken that national armaments will be reduced to the lowest point consistent with domestic safety.

Point XIV — League of Nations

> XIV. A general association of nations must be formed under specific covenants for the purpose of affording mutual guarantees of political independence and territorial integrity to great and small states alike.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The U.S. had entered World War I (1917); Russia's Bolsheviks had published secret Allied treaties, and nations debated what the postwar peace would look like.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Congress, the American public, the Allies and Central Powers, and peoples seeking independence; it was a speech to Congress meant for the world.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	President Woodrow Wilson, an idealist and progressive who believed in self-determination and collective security; colonized peoples outside Europe were largely overlooked.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. DBQ Evidence Beyond Docs (1 pt): Identify TWO outside pieces of evidence (people, events, treaties) you could use in an essay about Wilson and the post-WWI settlement.
2. Why did the U.S. Senate reject the Treaty of Versailles? Identify the key senator and his core objection.
3. Trace ONE specific Fourteen Point that DID survive — at the Paris conference or in later international law.

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> Wilson's blueprint for a lasting peace after World War I — open diplomacy, freedom of the seas, self-determination, and a "general association of nations" that became the League of Nations.

Wilson's framing

It will be our wish and purpose that the processes of peace, when they are begun, shall be absolutely open and that they shall involve and permit henceforth no secret understandings of any kind. The day of conquest and aggrandizement is gone by; so is also the day of secret covenants entered into in the interest of particular governments and likely at some unlooked-for moment to upset the peace of the world.

[. . .]

We entered this war because violations of right had occurred which touched us to the quick and made the life of our own people impossible unless they were corrected and the world secure once for all against their recurrence. What we demand in this war, therefore, is nothing peculiar to ourselves. It is that the world be made fit and safe to live in; and particularly that it be made safe for every peace-loving nation which, like our own, wishes to live its own life, determine its own institutions, be assured of justice and fair dealing by the other peoples of the world as against force and selfish aggression. All the peoples of the world are in effect partners in this interest, and for our own part we see very clearly that unless justice be done to others it will not be done to us. The programme of the world's peace, therefore, is our programme; and that programme, the only possible programme, as we see it, is this:

Selected points

I. Open covenants of peace, openly arrived at, after which there shall be no private international understandings of any kind but diplomacy shall proceed always frankly and in the public view.

II. Absolute freedom of navigation upon the seas, outside territorial waters, alike in peace and in war, except as the seas may be closed in whole or in part by international action for the enforcement of international covenants.

III. The removal, so far as possible, of all economic barriers and the establishment of an equality of trade conditions among all the nations consenting to the peace and associating themselves for its maintenance.

IV. Adequate guarantees given and taken that national armaments will be reduced to the lowest point consistent with domestic safety.

V. A free, open-minded, and absolutely impartial adjustment of all colonial claims, based upon a strict observance of the principle that in determining all such questions of sovereignty the interests of the populations concerned must have equal weight with the equitable claims of the government whose title is to be determined.

[. . .]

X. The peoples of Austria-Hungary, whose place among the nations we wish to see safeguarded and assured, should be accorded the freest opportunity to autonomous development. . . .

XIII. An independent Polish state should be erected which should include the territories inhabited by indisputably Polish populations, which should be assured a free and secure access to the sea, and whose political and economic independence and territorial integrity should be guaranteed by international covenant.

Point XIV - League of Nations

XIV. A general association of nations must be formed under specific covenants for the purpose of affording mutual guarantees of political independence and territorial integrity to great and small states alike.

[. . .]

Closing

For such arrangements and covenants we are willing to fight and to continue to fight until they are achieved; but only because we wish the right to prevail and desire a just and stable peace such as can be secured only by removing the chief provocations to war, which this programme does remove. . . . We wish her only to accept a place of equality among the peoples of the world, — the new world in which we now live, — instead of a place of mastery.

Words to know

aggrandizement — grabbing more territory or power for one's own nation

covenants — formal agreements between nations

touched us to the quick — hurt us deeply

armaments — weapons and military forces

sovereignty — the right to rule over a territory

autonomous — self-governing

territorial integrity — a nation's borders remaining whole and unviolated